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Resonance

TL;DR

Resonance is a framework for cognitive resolution and diegetic game design whose distinctive feature is ontological and perspectival resolution.

Resonance Core provides the generic engine: it turns what matters in a fictional situation into resolution.

Resonance Prisms determine how that resolution takes on meaning from a lived perspective of the world.

Glorantha Perspectives demonstrates one complete implementation.

The system does not define the world. **The world defines the system.**

And when mechanics become an extension of the fiction, **the player no longer plays the rules. They play the world.**

Resonance therefore starts from diegetic game design and pushes it toward perspectival resolution: not only does fiction determine what matters, but the way a character inhabits reality can determine how that reality is resolved.

A framework for cognitive resolution and ontological, perspectival game design

Resonance is not a roleplaying game.

It is a framework for designing roleplaying games in which **resolution emerges directly from the fiction.**

Instead of asking:

What is my character's percentage chance of success?

Resonance asks:

In this character and in this situation, what truly matters right now?

The player looks at the scene.

They identify what matters.

They bring the relevant elements of the fiction into the resolution.

Then the dice answer.

No calculations on the character sheet.

No hunting for the optimal modifier.

No mechanical interface between the player and the world.

The rule becomes an extension of the player's perception.

The idea behind Resonance

Most roleplaying games place a mechanical system between the player and the fictional world.

A character has attributes.

Those attributes become numbers.

Numbers become modifiers.

Modifiers interact with probabilities.

And eventually, a result tells us what happens.

Resonance proposes a different approach.

The fiction comes first

When a character attempts something, the player naturally considers:

- who the character is;
- what they have lived through;
- what they know;
- what they are carrying;
- who is helping them;
- what the environment is doing;
- what they fear;
- what they want;
- what stands in their way.

These elements are already meaningful.

Resonance simply gives them mechanical weight.

The question is not: *How good are you at this?*

It is: **What gives you leverage here?**

That is the fundamental idea behind **Resonance Core**.

Two complementary dimensions

Resonance rests on two distinct but inseparable operations.

Resonance Core selects the relevant reality: among everything that exists in the fiction, what matters for this intention, in this situation, right now?

Resonance Prisms determine how that relevant reality becomes consequence from a lived perspective.

The loop can be summarized as follows:

World → Relevance → Perspective → Resolution → Transformed world

There is therefore not necessarily any privileged mechanical reality outside the fiction: mechanics can become the local translation of a relationship to reality.

Playing with Resonance

Before explaining the concepts, here is the gesture at the table.

An example in a few seconds

GM: The stone door is beginning to close. What do you do?

Player: I run to get through before it shuts.

GM: All right. What matters here?

Player: I'm fast. And I was already running.

GM: Yes. But the floor is covered in rubble.

Player: Ah. And my leg is injured.

GM: Exactly. Anything else?

Silence.

GM: Then let's see what happens.

That is Resonance.

The fictional world contains an infinity of potential details. The table has just selected a few of them because they matter to a precise intention.

1. Intention

The player states what they are actually trying to achieve.

No dice yet.

I want to stop the guard from reaching the door.

2. Focus

The table clarifies the question that the resolution will decide.

Do you manage to stop them before they raise the alarm?

The **Focus** defines the relevant world for this resolution.

Not everything on the character sheet matters.

Not everything in the world matters.

The group determines what is relevant **now**.

3. Identify the Bets

Each side identifies the elements of the fiction that support its objective or hinder the opposing objective.

Those elements become **Bets**.

This is not about finding every possible advantage.

It is about identifying what genuinely matters in the current situation.

A character may be exceptional with a sword.

But if the current conflict is a political negotiation, that skill may not be a Bet.

The character may, however, owe a debt to the person they are negotiating with.

That relationship might be one.

The Focus determines what enters the resolution.

4. Follow-up and opposing Bets

A Bet can immediately reveal another relevant element.

Player: I'm already between him and the door.

GM: He knows this barracks perfectly.

Player: Exactly, and he has to get around me in this narrow corridor.

GM: But two soldiers are coming up behind you.

The conversation is not about artificially accumulating bonuses. It gradually makes the situation clear enough to resolve.

This dynamic also explains why oppositions tend to balance organically: a Bet can reveal an opposing Bet or shift the Focus.

5. Close the Bets

The question is not whether there is still something that *could* be added. In a rich fictional world, there are always more facts.

The criterion is simpler:

When nobody immediately sees anything else that still matters, roll the dice.

You do not search for a Bet. You notice it.

If someone has to comb through their character sheet, review every ability, or laboriously build a justification, they are probably leaving the Focus in order to search for a mechanical advantage.

The conversational ritual can be as simple as:

What matters here?

Anything else?

Silence.

Then let's see what happens.

6. Resolve

The relevant Bets determine the size of the resolution pool.

The dice are rolled.

But the dice do not decide everything on their own.

How the dice are interpreted depends on the game's Prisms.

Each Prism transforms its own pool according to its own logic and produces a common unit:

Successes.

Those Successes are then compared, not the raw dice of different Prisms.

7. Interpret

The result is not an isolated number.

It is a change in the fiction.

A narrow victory.

A decisive victory.

A failure.

A catastrophe.

A stalemate.

Resolution exists to answer the dramatic question and move the story forward.

Roll → interpret → the fiction changes.

The transformed world then becomes the starting point for the next situation.

Resonance Core

Immersion as the Engine

Resonance Core is **cognitive** because players simply immerse themselves in their character, and whether what they do generates valid Bets flows from that alone.

The player is no longer the accountant of their own statistics. Their only "workload" is to be present in the scene, embody their character, and pay attention to their surroundings. If their roleplay rings true and their reading of the situation is coherent, Bets emerge naturally without any calculation. That is the very definition of a reduced cognitive load.

And players only need to keep in mind the rules of their Prism, which resonates with their character and therefore with their roleplay.

A generic engine for resolving uncertainty through fiction

Resonance Core is the generic resolution engine at the heart of Resonance.

It does not define a setting.

It does not define a genre.

It does not define how characters progress.

It does not tell you what magic looks like, how combat works, or what the world believes.

It provides something simpler:

a way to turn what matters in a fictional situation into a resolution.

This is where Resonance introduces one of its fundamental concepts: the **Bet**.

Bets

Resonance uses a specific term for the fictional elements that can influence a resolution: **Bets**.

A Bet is not an abstract modifier attached to a character sheet.

It is something that exists in the fiction before it exists in the mechanics.

A Bet is a fictional element that the player chooses to place on the balance of the resolution.

It can be anything that matters in the current situation:

- a skill;
- an experience;
- an object;
- a relationship;
- an emotion;
- an environmental condition;
- a weakness;
- a cultural trait;
- an advantage created by the situation;
- or any other element that genuinely matters in the fiction.

A skill is not automatically a Bet.

An advantage is not automatically a Bet.

It becomes one when the player chooses to rely on it **here and now**.

Each Bet contributes to the resolution pool.

You are not calculating how competent your character is.

You are deciding **what you are betting on**.

In that sense, a Bet is a hypothesis about what will matter in the situation.

You may hope that your experience with the spear will give you the upper hand.

You may fear that your injured leg will weigh you down.

You may think that your opponent's fear will make them hesitate.

The dice then confront those Bets with those of the opposing side.

For example:

My character is wounded.

The bridge is collapsing.

I know this language.

The enemy is afraid.

It's raining.

If that element genuinely matters in the situation, it can become a Bet.

Bets and Stakes

Stakes are what can be won, lost, or changed in the situation.

A **Bet** is an element of the fiction placed on the balance because it may influence those Stakes.

For example:

Stakes: Cross the river before the guards arrive.

Bets: The character knows the river, the current is particularly strong, their companion is injured, and night is falling.

Stakes define what can be won or lost.

Bets define what each side believes can influence the outcome.

This distinction matters.

A Bet is not necessarily an advantage.

It can be something that helps you or something that works against you.

You can bet on your own strength.

You can bet on your opponent's weakness.

You can even bet on a dangerous circumstance if you believe it will influence the resolution in your favor.

So the important question is not whether something is objectively good or bad.

The question is:

Are you betting that it matters?

For games with lethality or a risk of injury, however, the GM should tell players whether an opposition presents a risk or not. This allows the player to reconsider their objective or plan and put themselves in a safer situation.

Resolution without an interface

Imagine a character trying to cross a dangerous battlefield.

A traditional system might ask:

What is your movement score?

What is the difficulty?

Do you have a bonus?

What is your final modifier?

Resonance asks something else:

What matters here?

For example:

- the character knows how armies move;
- their brother is waiting on the other side;
- artillery is falling around them;
- they are carrying an injured companion;
- the enemy has spotted them.

Those elements can become Bets — if the player chooses to lean on them.

The player is not searching their character sheet for a number.

They are looking at the world.

They may hope their knowledge of the battlefield will help.

They may fear that carrying an injured companion will slow them down.

They may decide that being spotted by the enemy is actually useful, because it draws attention away from their companions.

The player is not calculating probabilities.

They are making a judgment about what matters.

That is the cognitive experience Resonance seeks to produce.

Opposition and organic balance

In practice, Bets turn out to be fairly balanced when two sides or two opponents face off.

If a player brilliantly leans on the fiction to justify an extra Bet, that same level of detail often reveals an organic opposing Bet.

The difficulty of an obstacle often has less to do with the balance of a single opposition than with the fact that several oppositions may be required to overcome it. Each victory can be a small step toward final victory, or each failure toward final failure.

Zoom

Without a heavy mathematical interface, the GM can decide whether a conflict resolves at the scale of a single action, a complete sequence, or an entire script.

The same engine can therefore resolve a single gesture, a whole negotiation, a duel, or a larger sequence depending on the chosen **Zoom**.

This gives the table direct control over the pacing of play.

Frame Factor

Not everything that is true in the fiction can necessarily be placed on the balance as though the world had no limits.

A **Frame Factor** expresses a constraint that transforms the space of what can matter in a scene: the impossibility of violence in a sacred place, the protocol of a royal audience, extreme gravity, the presence of Chaos, a cultural prohibition, or another strong boundary.

It can make some Bets irrelevant and make others central.

The Frame Factor is therefore not merely an additional difficulty. It locally defines the reality within which the Focus operates.

The role of the GM and the table

The GM or the table validates whether a Bet is relevant or not.

That validation should not, however, rest solely on the GM's personal taste.

The game and its game design define which categories of truths can become relevant; the table knows them; the GM arbitrates their relevance in the present situation.

Since the technical load is minimal, the GM can focus on what makes the world alive and interactive:

- **Guaranteeing coherence (the Focus):** the GM listens to the players' Bets and rules on them to preserve the setting and the play contract. They apply the "Reality Check" to maintain the tone of the trope being played, or impose a *Frame Factor*.
- **Zero-sum play:** if a player brilliantly leans on the fiction to justify an extra Bet, the GM uses that same level of detail to lay down an organic opposing Bet when the fiction justifies it.
- **Managing scale (the Zoom):** the GM helps the table determine the scale at which the resolution should operate.

The Fate Gauge as a safety net

For groups that do not know each other, we recommend using a Fate Gauge as a safety net.

It allows you to keep track of imbalances. The gauge can be positive in favor of the protagonists (the PCs) or negative in favor of adversity (the GM).

It can be represented very simply by blue dice for the PCs or red dice for the GM.

It is shared by the group. It belongs to the general economy of the fiction. It is a kind of thermometer measuring the direction the narrative may potentially take.

The gauge evolves during oppositions before the roll:

Examples:

- An opposition that can be summarized as 5 Bets for the PC(s) against 3 Bets for the GM. The GM takes 2 red dice, i.e. the number of adversity dice they would have had to add to balance the opposition. The 5 vs 3 opposition is played out, regardless of the result. Later, the GM therefore has 2 red dice to spend in favor of an obstacle.
- Next opposition: 2 Bets for the PCs and 5 Bets for the GM. 3 blue dice are taken. Blue die/red die pairs cancel each other out. If the gauge contained 1 red die, 2 blue dice therefore remain in the gauge.

It does not necessarily apply to the very next obstacle, but the fiction regulates itself this way. It is the consensus of the table, accepted through the social contract.

There is therefore no longer any need to place blind trust in the GM to balance every scene. The system keeps track of imbalances.

But this device can disappear for tables whose players know each other well.

To summarize, the Fate Gauge is a safety device for certain social configurations.

For a table that knows each other: “We know how to play together.” → a safety net is not necessarily needed.

For a table with strangers: “We don’t yet know how everyone understands the fictional contract.” → Gauge active.

And gradually, if the table builds that trust, it can even decide: “We don’t need it anymore.”

Resonance Prisms

From diegesis to mechanical ontology

The Core deliberately leaves something open:

How does reality become mechanically accessible from a character’s lived perspective?

That is the role of **Prisms**.

A Prism is not simply a thematic way of coloring the same roll. It defines a resolution grammar that expresses a lived conception of reality.

The Prism does not describe what you do. It describes the world in which you think you are doing it.

The same Core can therefore produce radically different experiences.

A materialist world may treat the dice as indifferent physical probability.

A world ruled by gods may allow faith to alter outcomes.

An animist world may allow spirits to intervene.

A mystical world may treat apparent success and failure as illusions.

A technological world may turn patterns, sequences, or calculations into meaningful elements.

The Core selects what matters.

The Prism determines how what matters becomes consequence.

Same world, different perspectives

Two characters can observe the same phenomenon, possess the same information, use the same object, or perform the same procedure without cognitively inhabiting the same world.

The Prism therefore represents neither a profession, nor a cognitive skill, nor a temporary method selected because it gives a better dice effect.

It represents a lived perspective deep enough to become operative in resolution.

The Prism represents the world's reaction when you try to learn the outcome of your Bets

A good Prism answers questions such as:

Is gameplay a reflection of the roleplay we want to bring out?

What does this universe consider true?

What does it consider possible?

What does it reward?

What does it punish?

What does it make dangerous?

How does the world's philosophy affect uncertainty?

The result is a powerful inversion of traditional game design.

Instead of:

Rules → fiction

Resonance aims to produce:

Fiction → rules

And, more precisely:

World → Relevance → Perspective → Resolution → Transformed world

Lore is no longer merely something players read.

It becomes something they use.

Different Prisms, a common output

Dice from different Prisms are not compared directly.

Each Prism has its own grammar for transforming Bets into **Successes**.

Successes then become the common language of resolution.

Bets → Prism → Successes → comparison → consequence

A Prism is therefore not designed as a different way to obtain more Successes, but as **a different way for chance to make sense**.

The generic Prism (default)

As mentioned in the Resonance Core section, there is an agnostic, materialist Prism that is very simple to understand and use.

- A Bet is represented by a die.
- Each side rolls its dice together.
- We no longer track which element each Bet was based on.
- Count the even numbers.
- An even die counts as one Success.
- Compare each side's number of Successes:
 - Tie: stalemate or minor setback.
 - Difference of 1: victory or defeat depending on the side.
 - Difference of 2 or more: exploit or fiasco.

You can even play in any universe with this single Prism. It is self-sufficient for steering the fiction in a random yet realistic way while remaining grounded in the fiction.

Outbidding

When a stalemate is impossible or unwanted (a tie), both sides may reroll their dice, adding 1 Bet per side to simulate the determination to settle things once and for all, repeating until a clear outcome emerges.

Once the pools of Bets grow substantial enough, stalemates become rarer and rarer.

A pool spanning several Prisms

It is possible to calculate the result of a side containing several Prisms. Imagine the PCs jointly facing an obstacle (negotiation, combat): each forms their own pool and calculates their number of Successes, which are then added together and compared against adversity's total. In case of fiasco or defeat, whoever obtained the fewest Successes is affected first.

Characters with several Prisms

Generally speaking, characters have only one Prism, the one that resonates with their roleplay and lived perspective.

But one can imagine games that modify the Prism depending on the environment or certain contexts, provided that this modification genuinely expresses a transformation in the relationship to the world rather than simply an opportunistic choice of mechanics.

This avenue is explored in Glorantha Perspectives with heroic modes and weakened modes.

One can imagine modified or completely unique Prisms in a CyberPunk world as soon as characters enter the Matrix, for example.

One engine. Different realities.

The Core determines what enters the resolution. The Prism determines how what enters it becomes consequence.

The Core thus remains the common kernel, while Prisms allow different lived realities to produce different resolution grammars.

Designing a game with Resonance

Designed for worlds that matter

Resonance is particularly suited to games where the world itself matters.

Worlds with:

- deep lore;
- competing philosophies;
- meaningful cultures;
- strange metaphysics;
- strong relationships;
- symbolic environments;
- universes where *how you understand reality* matters as much as what you are physically capable of.

Because the mechanics do not need to encode every possible action separately, the same Core can handle:

a duel, a negotiation, an investigation, a ritual, a chase, a battle, a journey, or a political conflict.

Resolution changes because the **fiction changes**, not because a new subsystem must be learned.

Designed for game designers

Resonance changes the role of the game designer.

You no longer primarily need to design:

- hundreds of modifiers;

- exhaustive skill lists;
- rules for every possible situation;
- ever more complex combat subsystems.

Instead, you design the elements that make your world unique.

You create the fiction

Its: **lore, beliefs, cultures, relationships, myths, taboos, metaphysics...**

You define what can matter

What can become a Bet?

What should never become one?

What does the game want players to notice?

You design the Prisms

How does this world respond to uncertainty?

How do its philosophy, archetype, or trope transform resolution?

What happens when a character acts against the fundamental logic of the world?

You define the boundaries

What is impossible?

What is forbidden?

What cannot simply be overcome by adding another argument?

These are the design choices that give a Resonance game its identity.

Designing what matters

Relevance is not only a matter of table arbitration. It is also a game design tool.

Fictional truth, eligible Bet, relevant Bet

Three levels can be distinguished:

1. **True in the fiction:** a fact, relationship, object, emotion, or constraint exists in the world.
2. **Eligible in this game:** the game design recognizes that category of truth as something that may carry weight in the fiction.
3. **Relevant here:** the Focus and the situation make that truth actually matter to the present resolution.

Not every fictional truth is therefore automatically a Bet.

A grammar of relevance

The game designer can define what the game invites players to notice:

- relationships and obligations;
- honor, reputation, or shame;
- belonging to a clan, community, or institution;
- passions and attachments;
- knowledge, discipline, or training;
- social status;
- territory and environment;
- the sacred, taboo, omens, or cosmology;
- fear, corruption, desire, guilt;
- or any other category of causality specific to the world or genre.

These categories do not necessarily form a closed list of abilities. Rather, they define **what the game teaches players to look at**.

The designer's question becomes:

Among everything that is true in the fiction, which truths does this game recognize as relevant?

Trope and relevance

A game can produce a genre not only by defining significant actions, but also by defining the reasons that can carry weight in the fiction.

Approaches such as PbtA strongly encode genre through Moves, their triggers, and archetypes. Resonance operates at another level: it can leave the space of actions largely open while orienting the space of relevance.

PbtA can strongly constrain the forms of meaningful action; Resonance can constrain the forms of meaningful relevance.

Resonance therefore does not necessarily tell the player what to do in order to produce the trope; it teaches them **what to look at and which reasons to recognize** so that the trope can emerge from their own actions.

The character and their space of relevance

This approach also opens up a form of progression that is not only quantitative.

A character can evolve because the reasons capable of carrying weight for them change.

A young warrior may begin with a grammar dominated by clan, master, duty, reputation, and obedience, then see compassion, personal love, doubt, truth, or refusal of an unjust order emerge.

The character does not necessarily gain an ability. **Their space of relevance changes.**

Continuity between trope, Frame Factor, Focus, Bets, and Prism

The architecture can be summarized as follows:

The game and its trope determine what can carry weight.

The Frame Factor transforms what can carry weight here.

The Focus determines what carries weight now.

The Bets express why it carries weight.

The Prism determines how the world responds.

Designing Prisms

Start from the fictional experience

A Prism is not, first of all, a dice gimmick.

The starting point is the fictional, cognitive, or ontological experience the game wants to produce: what way of inhabiting the world should become perceptible in the act of resolution?

The rule comes afterward.

Identify the logic of the Prism

Before choosing a mechanic, identify what characterizes this perspective: relations, accumulation, transcendence, intervention, balance, patterns, determinism, sacrifice, contamination, reciprocity, or any other logic specific to the world.

The question is less “what dice effect would be original?” than:

What logic of reality should become perceptible when the player resolves uncertainty?

Translate that logic into a mechanical operation

Once that logic has been identified, choose the operations that can make it perceptible: evens and odds, sums, patterns, cancellations, rerolls, changes in die size, cards, colors, interactions between pools, or other components.

The choice of component comes after the meaning it is meant to produce.

Check what the Prism makes the player play

A good Prism does not merely represent an idea. It influences what the player notices, hopes for, fears, or seeks when resolving uncertainty.

The test can be summarized in one question:

Does playing this Prism effectively push the player to look at the world as their character does?

Check comparability

Radically different Prisms must be able to participate in the same resolution.

Their internal grammar can vary, but they must produce an output that can be compared through the common engine — generally **Successes**.

Bets → Prism grammar → Successes → comparison → consequence

Avoid the gimmick

A Prism is not “sixes explode because that is fun.”

Sixes explode if that mechanical property expresses something about the reality lived by the character and produces the desired experience at the table.

The mechanic is not decorated by the lore: **it becomes an operation of the lore.**

Examples of possible Prisms (non-exhaustive)

It is up to you to invent Prisms for your game. Here are some leads.

Note: you will also find examples of other Prisms with variants in Glorantha Perspectives.

Manipulating Patterns and Probabilities

- **The Prism of Prophecy (Commitment):** Before rolling, the player must announce *the exact number* of Successes (e.g. even numbers) they will obtain. Hitting it exactly generates an absolute exploit. Any other result is a failure. *Diegesis: Oracles, prescience, time mages. The player is incentivized to sabotage themselves (reduce their Bets) to guarantee their own prediction.*
- **The Prism of Balance (Duality):** The player must split their Bets into two distinct pools (e.g. white dice and black dice). Success depends not on the raw result, but on the *small difference* between the sums of the two pools. The closer the gap to zero, the purer the success. *Diegesis: Monks of balance, Yin/Yang manipulation, or opposed elemental forces.*

Direct Interaction with Adversity

- **The Prism of Symbiosis (Mimicry):** One of the player’s dice counts as a Success *only* if it shows exactly the same value as a die in the opposing pool. You do not win by crushing the obstacle, but by entering into resonance with it. *Diegesis: Telepathy, absolute diplomacy, alien assimilation, or neural hacking.*
- **The Parasite Prism (Corruption):** The player’s “1”s allow them to physically swap their own dice with the opponent’s highest dice before the final interpretation. *Diegesis: Horror, necromancy, curses where one feeds on the strength of another.*

The Nature of Components

- **The Weaver's Prism (Playing cards):** Each Bet lets you draw a card. Combinations (pairs, runs) define the number of Successes, but the majority *suit* of the hand (Spades, Hearts, Diamonds, Clubs) dictates the narrative consequence (injury, moral debt, revelation). *Diegesis: Manipulators of fate, illusionists.*
- **The Prism of Ascension (Variable dice):** Bets justify the *size* of the dice (e.g. D4 for a minor detail, D12 for a major asset). To score an Exploit, the player must form an ascending run (e.g. 2-3-4) using dice of necessarily different sizes (D4, D6, D8). *Diegesis: Ever-evolving entities, mutants, or heroes breaking through their limits (shōnen).*

The Prisms of Isolation (Singularity) The goal here is to make the presence of allies mechanically penalizing, pushing the character to act as a lone wolf or isolate themselves to unlock their full potential.

- **Mechanical Abstraction (Dilution):** Before rolling, the player gathers their N Bets. For each ally physically present in the scene (or involved in the conflict), the player must discard one of their dice, or cancel their best Success after the roll.
- **Inverse Mechanical Abstraction (Awakening of the Void):** If and only if the character is the sole protagonist in the scene, all of their odd dice (normally failures) may be rerolled, or their failures cancel opposing Successes.
- **Diegetic Translations:**
 - *The Cursed Berserker:* Their rage is a blind storm. With allies around, they must hold back their blows (lost Bets). Alone, they become an absolute killing machine.
 - *The Shadow Assassin:* Their magic relies on the silence of the weave. The presence of other souls “makes noise” and disrupts their probabilities.
 - *The Keeper of Secrets:* Their power involves forbidden knowledge. If an ally witnesses their action, the power dries up to preserve the secret.

The Prisms of Synergy (Gestalt) Here, the individual is nothing without the group. Success is no longer individual; it emerges from the intersection of actions.

- **Mechanical Abstraction (Crossed Resonance):** The player rolls their N Bets. Standard even numbers do not count. A Success is generated *only* if one of their dice shows exactly the same value as a die rolled by an ally during that same round/conflict.
- **Mechanical Abstraction (The Network):** The size of the base pool is fixed, but each ally present in the scene allows the player to automatically turn one failed die into a Success, or alter parity (e.g. with 3 allies, 1s, 3s, and 5s also become Successes).

- **Diegetic Translations:**

- *The Collective Consciousness*: Extraterrestrials, telepathic twins, or networked artificial intelligences. They do not think “I,” they think “We.”
- *The Perfect Phalanx*: An elite military squad (like Lunar hoplites) where each member’s survival depends exclusively on their neighbor’s shield.
- *The Magic Chorus*: Mages whose incantations require harmonizing their frequencies to alter reality.

Parasitic Prisms (Toxic Dependence) Collaboration is forced, but asymmetric. One character shines, yet their success comes at the direct expense of the allies present.

- **Mechanical Abstraction (Drain)**: The character generates automatic Successes or gains extra Bets by *physically stealing them* from the Bet pools of allies present in the scene.
- **Mechanical Abstraction (Human Shield)**: Each “1” rolled by this player cancels their own defeat, but instantly removes the best Success of a nearby ally. If there is no ally, the “1” turns against the player.
- **Diegetic Translations:**
 - *The Psychic Vampire / The Necromancer*: They siphon the life force of their companions to fuel their own miracles.
 - *The Toxic Boss / The Arrogant Noble*: A commander who takes credit for subordinates’ work and throws them under the bus at the first problem.

Conclusion — Relevance

Resonance starts from a simple idea: a fictional world always contains more truths than a resolution can take into account.

Playing therefore begins by determining **what matters**.

Not what the character sheet allows.

Not which modifier is most advantageous.

But what, for this character, in this situation, and in relation to this intention, genuinely carries weight.

That is relevance.

Resonance Core transforms that relevance into resolution.

Prisms determine how that resolution takes on meaning from a lived perspective.

Players stop asking:

What is my best modifier?

and start asking:

What do I see?

What do I know?

What does my character believe?

What is happening around me?

What are the real Stakes?

The player then stops searching for the rule that describes the world.

They look at the world to discover the rule that applies.

Relevance is the cognitive heart of Resonance. Prisms are its ontological and perspectival extension: they do not merely say what matters, but how what matters becomes consequence from a situated way of inhabiting reality.

The world defines the system. Perception selects what matters. The Prism determines how the world responds.

Case Studies

Resonance: Glorantha

A concrete implementation

A framework becomes interesting when it can step off the page.

Resonance: Glorantha shows what happens when Resonance is fully embedded in a specific fictional universe.

Glorantha is not simply handed a generic resolution system.

Its cosmology, religions, and various ways of understanding reality themselves become integral parts of resolution.

The same underlying engine can therefore produce radically different experiences depending on whether the character apprehends reality through:

Theism Even numbers are Successes.

Sixes can produce extraordinary outcomes and interact with results that would otherwise be failures.

Faith changes the meaning of failure.

Animism Even numbers are Successes.

Certain patterns among failed dice can become Successes.

The world is populated by possibilities that do not behave like ordinary causality.

Logic Dice are not interpreted as mere Successes or failures.

Their values are summed and processed according to a deterministic rule.

Uncertainty becomes calculation.

Mysticism Certain results can negate an opponent's apparent Successes.

Material victory becomes secondary to a deeper reality.

Draconism Bets are represented by D8s to mark the difference. Certain patterns in the result (the Ouroboros or the egg's stasis) produce extra Successes, but they come at a price.

The choice between the Wyrms and Utuma.

Lunar influence For followers of the Red Moon, the new or full moon alters the character's Prism (whether animist, theist, or logician).

This change creates a focus on the 1 — the small, the nothing — preparing Lunars for potential Illumination.

Illumination The game makes it possible to play the moment of Illumination realistically and within the fiction. The character genuinely becomes illuminated in gameplay and in the game.

The character understands that the universe is one vast joke.

Hero Quests The game even encourages players to seek out new Prisms. Will they find the Prism that will change the face of the world, just as the Red Moon did in her youth?

These variations are not cosmetic. They create different cognitive experiences.

The player does not merely learn the lore of the world.

They think through its philosophy. And even when the player rolls dice or draws cards, their way of reading the result resonates with the character.

The system does not merely describe the world.

It makes the player experience the world through its own logic.

Glorantha Perspectives is the proof of concept and the detailed implementation of the framework.

[Read the Glorantha Perspectives SRD →](#)

Resonance: Scooby Doo

I had fun building a small, lightweight game quickly using Resonance's game design. Here is the result.

It is more a proof of concept than anything else. It does not have the depth of Glorantha Perspectives.

The Lore

The starting point is simple: You are a bunch of college friends. No tragic backstory, no debts, no complex narrative arcs. It is summer break, you have refurbished an old van, and you cruise the roads of the United States listening to music.

Except that every time you stop for gas or a burger, you run into an incompetent sheriff, an abandoned amusement park, and a plastic monster.

Character Creation (The Archetypes)

Players pick an archetype. They browse a list of suggested keywords: keeping the ones that make them laugh, crossing out the ones they dislike, and inventing new ones if inspired.

Pretty Boy (with the terrible plan) *The self-proclaimed leader, charismatic but usually off target. He loves giving orders that make no sense.*

- **Physical/Mental keywords:** Square jaw, Ultra-bright smile, Self-assured, Natural authority, Boy Scout leader aura, IQ inversely proportional to his looks.
- **Action keywords:** Obsessed with elaborate traps, Rube Goldberg, “Let’s split up into two groups”, Driver’s license.
- **Suggested bonds:** Secretly in love with the Lovely Klutz (who does not notice), or admires himself a little too much in the rearview mirror.

Lovely Klutz *The one who attracts trouble like a magnet. She seems fragile, but her handbag defies the laws of physics.*

- **Physical/Mental keywords:** Always impeccable wardrobe, Refreshing naivety, Glass-shattering shriek, Danger-prone (attracts trapdoors and ghosts).
- **Action keywords:** Magic handbag (holds anything and everything), Tactical makeup, Black belt in shopping, Lockpicking with a bobby pin.
- **Suggested bonds:** In love with no one (too independent), or unknowingly flirts with the monster.

Brainiac *The brains of the group. Skeptical, sarcastic, she is the only one reading encyclopedias over summer break.*

- **Physical/Mental keywords:** Severe myopia (“My glasses!”), Suffocating turtleneck sweater, Absolute skepticism, Sarcastic, Walking encyclopedia.
- **Action keywords:** Relentless deduction, Finding the hidden light switch, Unintelligible scientific jargon, Crawling on the floor.
- **Suggested bonds:** Secretly in love with Pretty Boy, or privately looks down on the group’s intellectual level.

The Clumsy Duo (Played by 2 players!) *Magnificent cowards. All they think about is eating and running away — and that is often what saves the day.*

- **Player A (The Spaced-Out Dude):**

- *Keywords:* Always high (or just spacey), Freakish metabolism, Olympic-level coward, “Not even in your dreams”, Belly on legs, Destructive appetite.

- **Player B (The Pet):**

- *Keywords:* Talking dog (or raccoon, giant iguana...), Human mannerisms, Competitive scaredy-cat, Easily bribed (for a treat), Sniffs out trouble.

- **Shared bond:** They are inseparable, have their own language, and often pass for one another.

The 5th Member: The Vehicle Sheet

The van is the heart of the team. The whole table picks its keywords together. It generates diegetic problems before the monster even shows up.

The Van (model TBD)

- **Its look:** Psychedelic paint job, Rust hidden under stickers, Right headlight that blinks on its own.
- **How it runs:** Engine that coughs when people panic, Out of gas in the middle of nowhere, Starts right up (but only if it gets time to warm up).
- **Its fittings:** Secret and infinite snack stash, Questionable mattress, Sound system worthy of a 70s rock festival, Chemistry lab improvised by the Brainiac.

The rules of the game

“In this game, we are not going to look for modifiers on a sheet — the mechanics live in the situation.

. You tell me what you do, leaning on your Keywords.

For every relevant and funny element, I give you a die (a Bet).

*Golden rule for everyone: **even dice are successes, odd dice are failures.** You will always know how many successes you scored — except the Klutz, who just needs to roll pretty patterns ;).*

BUT, the way the universe (and I, the GM) reacts to your successes depends on your character. Fred, you will find the universe has a particular sense of humor about your plans. Sammy, you will discover that running away screaming is a viable strategy. Do not worry about consequences, play your clichés to the fullest, count your evens, and I will handle the magic of video editing!”

This way:

1. Players get a clear, mathematical mechanic to rely on (counting evens).
2. You preserve the mystery of asymmetric interpretation (your twist).
3. You take the pressure off: they will reach for their keywords to earn dice instead of dumbly trying to “optimize” the action.

The different Prisms

The Clumsy Duo: The Draw Without Opposition The world does not oppose them — they oppose themselves!

- *Gameplay*: They gather their fear-and-hunger Bets and roll their dice alone.
- *Interpretation*: The result just indicates the *scale of chaos* they generate. If they score lots of Successes, their flight is so chaotic it destroys the monster’s hiding spot.
- Together they are stronger: the GM adds pairs of odd numbers when comparing the two draws. But they still do not merge into a common pool. If Sammy rolls two 3s, it does not count as a Success. It only counts if Scooby-Doo also rolls a 3. That incentivizes them to stay together.

Brainiac: The Draw With Opposition (Logic) She is the only one anchored in reality. She plays a “normal” RPG.

- *Gameplay*: She lays down her Bets, the GM lays down theirs. This is classic resolution, where the dice confront Bets against the opposing side.
- *Interpretation*: Rational. If she wins, she finds a clue. If she loses, she loses her glasses or gets it wrong.

Pretty Boy: The Offset and the Reversal A draw that “resonates” crooked is excellent for emulating his trope.

- *Gameplay*: He makes a draw with opposition against the GM.
- *Interpretation (the secret Twist)*: The outcome is **inverted**.
 - *If he wins*: His plan works *exactly* as intended... but on the wrong target (the net falls on the Clumsy Duo). He believes he succeeded, but narratively it is a disaster.
 - *If he loses (GM Exploit)*: The plan collapses miserably... and it is precisely the pulley coming loose that knocks out the ghost. The player curses his dice, but the GM announces total victory!

Lovely Klutz: The Magnet The Klutz could play with pink dice, if you have some.

Involuntary Charm (Crossed Pairs)

- **The Rule:** If one of her pink dice forms an exact pair with the GM's highest die (or a "6"), the monster is awestruck, charmed, or completely distracted by her.
- **The Fiction:** The monster stops mid-roar to pick up the mirror she dropped. Or she looks at it wide-eyed and says: *"But... you are the museum curator, not a werewolf!"*, creating an awkward silence. The opposition is literally neutralized by seduction or innocence, without any fight.

The Plot "Oops" (Runs)

Tell the Klutz that her goal is to form runs (or identical numbers), because they are pretty. That encourages her to take simple actions with few Bets: her klutzy side — no elaborate schemes.

- **The Rule:** If her dice form a run (e.g. 2-3-4 or 3-4-5 or 1-1-1 etc.), regardless of whether she succeeds or fails against adversity, she triggers an "Oops."
- **The Fiction:** She tips the story in a notable way. She leans against a fake bookshelf to retie her lace and opens the secret lair. She presses the red button thinking she is turning on the light and disables the force field. She finds the plot shortcut by pure accident.

Otherwise, nothing happens?

If she makes neither a run nor a pair with the monster, and "misses" her roll, the consequence for her is never violence or death (this is Scooby-Doo).

- For her, failure simply means: she breaks a nail, gets separated from the group, or gets locked in a VIP room with a tray of petit fours while waiting to be rescued. The monster never harms her; it just puts her "aside."

□ **The Mystery of the Last Fry Motel**

The Pitch (opening scene) It is night, pouring rain. The Van breaks down (the GM uses the Van sheet's keywords to justify black smoke under the hood). The team is forced to stop at the **"Bates Burger & Motel"**, a seedy 1950s roadside stop lost on an abandoned road. The manager, old Mr. Grossi, welcomes them trembling: *"Run... The Ghost of the Mad Cook is back! He haunts the kitchens with his fluorescent spatula!"*

The Monster The Ghost of the Mad Cook: A specter covered in glistening grease, shrieking terrifying recipes, walking through walls (apparently).

Main Obstacle: Solving the Mystery To unmask the monster, the team must gather **3 Keys** (the GM keeps their exact nature secret until the players uncover them through their actions):

1. **The Motive:** Beneath the kitchen lies an old smuggling cellar full of Prohibition-era liquor worth a fortune.
2. **The Trickery:** Jars of phosphorescent paint and a map of the dumbwaiter network (which lets the ghost vanish from floor to floor).
3. **The Culprit:** It is actually the local real estate developer, Mr. Zellani, who wants to terrify old Grossi so he can buy the motel for next to nothing.

The 3 Acts (how to let your Prisms shine)

Act 1: First Contact (around a cold burger)

- **The Scene:** The group settles in to eat while the Van cools down. Suddenly, the lights flicker and the Mad Cook bursts out of the kitchen fridge screaming!
- **Expected mechanics:**
 - This is the perfect moment for a *Draw Without Opposition* by the **Clumsy Duo**, attempting to flee with the biggest sandwich they can carry.
 - **Pretty Boy** will surely shout: “*Let’s split up to surround the kitchen!*” (justifying his keyword).

Act 2: Exploring the Motel (hunting the Keys) The monster prowls the motel. The group searches for clues (the 3 Keys).

- **Room 13 (Lovely Klutz):** She goes to touch up her makeup in an abandoned room. The ghost appears! If she rolls a run with her pink dice (the plot *Oops*), she grabs the coat rack while screaming, pivoting the wall and revealing the dumbwaiter network (Key #2 found!).
- **The boiler room (Brainiac):** While inspecting the pipes, the monster attacks her. She makes her choice: she loses her glasses (failed roll, covered in soot), but feeling along the floor, she finds a dry-cleaning ticket in the name of Mr. Costard (Key #3 found!).

Act 3: The Grand Trap (the climax) Now that the group understands something is going on, they must capture the ghost.

- **The Scene:** Pretty Boy devises a plan involving luggage carts, tomato sauce, and a giant fan.
- **Expected mechanics:** This is his moment of glory. He makes his opposed draw with reversal. The monster slips on the puddle of tomato sauce, destroys Pretty Boy’s trap, but knocks itself out against the fridge door!

Epilogue We rip off the plastic mask: “Mr. Zellani?!”

“And I would have gotten away with it if it weren’t for you and that blasted dog!”

Timeline Character and Van selection: ~15 to 20 minutes

This is the icebreaker phase.

- Reading the sheets is immediate.
- Players spend 10 minutes making the keywords their own (crossing some out, adding one or two) and defining their bonds (who loves whom, who despises whom).
- Creating the Van takes 5 minutes of collective debate (deciding whether it is rusty or smells of cold pizza).

The rules “pitch”: ~5 minutes

This is the great advantage of your diegetic approach: the mental load sits with you.

- You have no complex mechanics to explain.
- You announce the social contract (the GM guarantees the fiction, keywords yield dice, even numbers are Successes).
- You drop a teaser about how the universe will react differently to each of them. It goes by very fast.

The Session (the scenario): ~1h30 to 2h00

The pace of a cartoon-style mystery must stay brisk, or the joke wears thin.

- **Act 1 - Arrival and the first scare (20 to 30 min):** Time to set the mood, give voice to the old NPC manager, and trigger the monster’s first appearance to send everyone running.
- **Act 2 - Exploring (45 to 60 min):** This is the heart of the game. Fred splits the group. We cut from the Brainiac searching for clues to the Klutz opening secret passages by mistake, while the Clumsy Duo raids the kitchen. As soon as you have dealt out the 3 Keys (the Motive, the Trickery, the Culprit), cut it short and move to the finale.
- **Act 3 - The botched trap and the reveal (20 to 30 min):** Planning the scheme, rolling dice (with those famous reversals), the absurd capture, and the unmasked villain’s monologue.

The slowdown factor (the Reality Check)

At a real table, what eats time with narrative games is **negotiating the Bets**. Players will try to bend the fiction to justify dice. To keep the 2-hour window, your job as GM is to rule fast, always favoring humor: *“No, your turtleneck doesn’t help you run faster, but if you tell me you trip because of your myopia, I’ll give you the die.”*